

Dawn Johnston Truth and Reconciliation Blanket

Aboriginal and Treaty Right Litigation, 2018





The initial vision for this blanket began early on in this course, as I started to reflect upon the sacredness of blankets for so many of us as Indigenous peoples as well as the significance they have in the history of colonialism and genocide for our peoples. As a Nehiyaw (Cree) woman, I wanted to bring in an aspect of my own identity and our starblanket to tell this story. Because most of the cases we studied were based in British Columbia, I also wanted to incorporate an aspect of a blanket which is significant to many nations along the west coast; the button blanket.

As Indigenous people, blankets and blanketing are an important aspect of who we are, our ceremonies, our protocols, and our laws. We use blankets to wrap our dead, to join couples in marriage, in our regalia to tell a story and to represent ones standing within the community, as currency, and in gifting. Some nations stand upon blankets in our ceremonies, and others wrap in it to protect the heart and the spirit from negative energy that may be present. In modern day, we use blankets to cover our sweatlodges. The process of blanketing someone is considered sacred, as we wrap them up to show they are safe and protected. This is only a brief summary of the importance and sacredness of blankets to our people, and why I chose this method to visually represent our laws.

The starblanket itself has two significant meanings. Prior to contact, we would paint and stitch this design on buffalo hides. After the buffalo, and in turn their hides, began to decline, we started to use fabrics and materials traded from early settlers. The center of the star represents Creators eye; that we are always being looked after but also that we are always being watched to ensure that we are living within the laws that Creator set for us. The star itself represents the morning star, signifying the rise of a new day each morning. The button blanket frame is a simple version of a Kwakwaka'wakw design. The triangles on each side are meant to be mountains; sometimes used as a symbol of wealth and strength. Each design on the border of a button blanket tells a story; about one's name, their family lineage, the wealth of their chief, or their role within the community. These designs are made with intention to indicate to others who someone is and/or where they come from.

Within the star I wanted to show representations of our laws as Indigenous peoples, so chose symbols that could begin to tell this story: the sacred canupa (pipe), which was used to create legal relations and contracts with one another; a copper shield, which was used to show wealth and used as a form of currency and also to signify shame when someone went against the laws of the community, through the breaking of a copper; the regalia and dance of the Nisgaa people; the pole raised at Gwaii Hanaas; a symbol of our stewardship of the land through protecting water and the environment. The most important aspect I wanted to include here though was our languages. The quote that hit me most strongly throughout this entire course was: *"our land ends where our language ends"*. I found that statement so simple yet so powerful, and so wanted to include the names of Indigenous lands in Indigenous languages. I also felt it was important to incorporate our languages as they are representative of our laws and the oral tradition of our laws. Definitions for those included words are as follows:

- *čəsnaʔəm*: a Musqueam village otherwise known as the 'Marpole midden' and the site of a large occupation and demonstration in 2011.
- *Lhukw'lhukw'áytən*: Otherwise known as Burnaby Mountain and the location of where the proposed Kinder Morgan pipeline will travel through.
- Gingolx : One of the four Nisgaa communities, and translated from their language to mean "place of the skulls"; a warning to others who attempted to invade Nisgaa lands.
- Musgamagw Dzawadeneuk: One of the tribes of the Kwakwaka'wakw who are engaged in litigation to stop fish farms from operating within their tradition territories.
- Wahkohtowin: Cree Natural Law, which can be translated to mean interconnectedness and relatedness; essentially that we are related to all of Creation.
- Tapwewin: The act of telling the truth (in Cree)





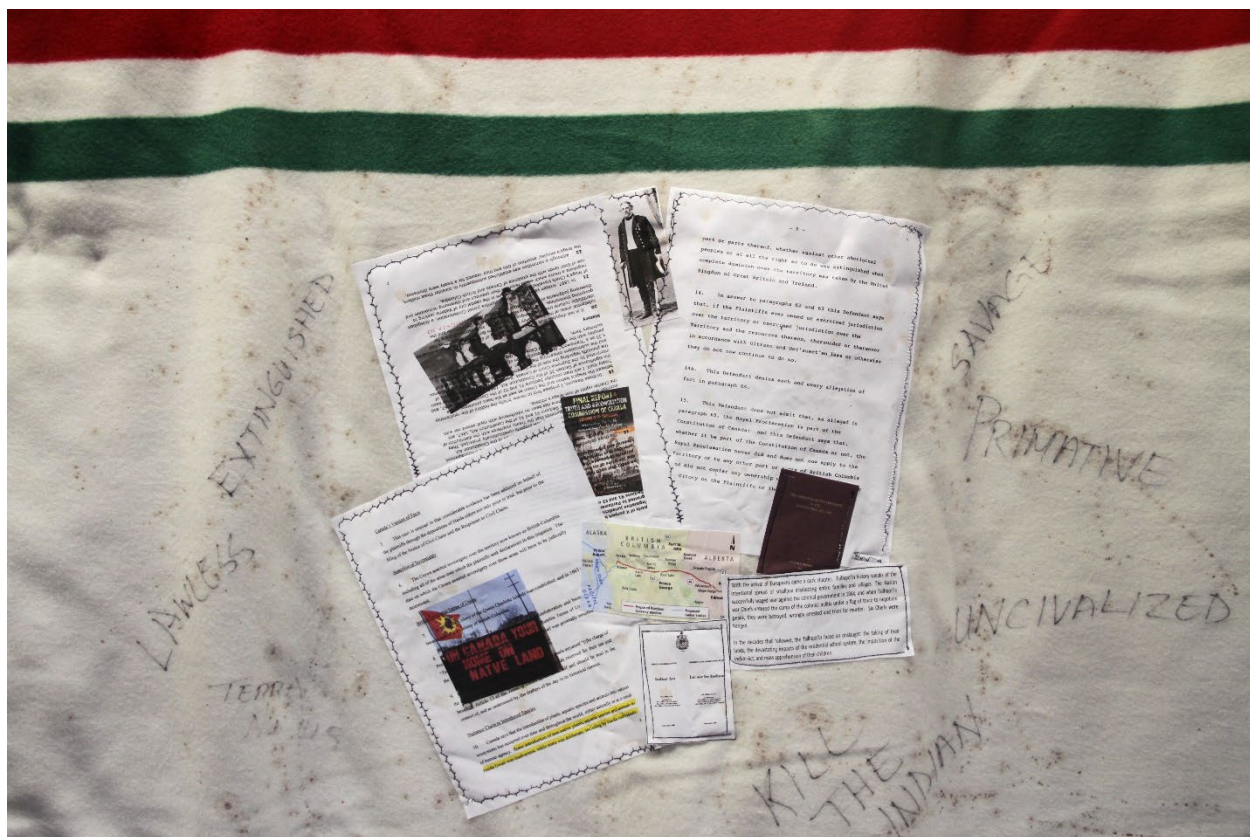


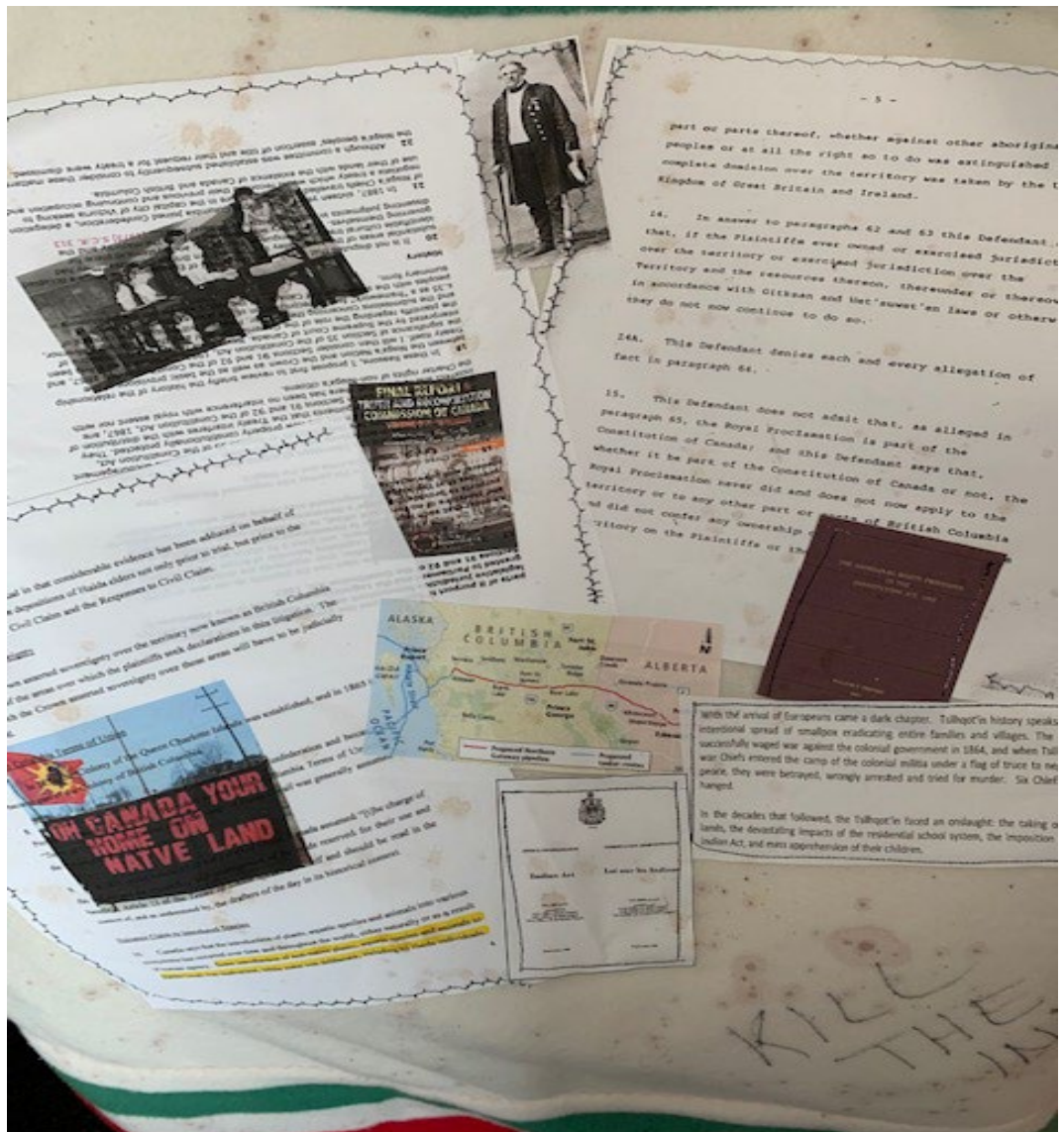
On the reverse, I brought in the Hudson's Bay blanket. This blanket has been a symbol of trade, treaties, and smallpox for Indigenous people across this country. In many of the cases studied, and also in what we know from what has been shared from this time, blankets were used as a means of creating agreements with Indigenous people. In the story of the Douglas Treaties with the Tsawout people, it was shared that these blankets were left with guns along the shorelines. At other times during early colonization, these blankets were infested with smallpox and given to Indigenous people; killing entire villages from the disease. Most boldly stated, these blankets are a symbol of broken promises and murder. The Hudson's Bay blanket was cut and restitched in red thread to signify these broken promises and the blood shed in trying to piece things back together. The red splatter across this side of the blanket is also a symbol of the blood shed and the lives lost during these interactions with the colonizers. Stitched onto this side are representations of the colonial legal system, and its attempt to continue to deny Aboriginal rights, and also Indigenous laws. The words speak to the attitudes and belief systems that this oppression was based in, and the images show some of the people and tools that were used to achieve the goal of oppression and assimilation; displacement from lands, broken treaties, and residential schools.

Finally, the last corner of the blanket is unfinished. Some of the loose threads remain uncut. Some pieces of the fabric are frayed. This is to symbolize the various imperfections in that exist in our colonial legal system, and also to symbolize that this

work is unfinished. We still have big and small pieces of work to complete before we can truly move to a place of reconciliation in law with Indigenous people.

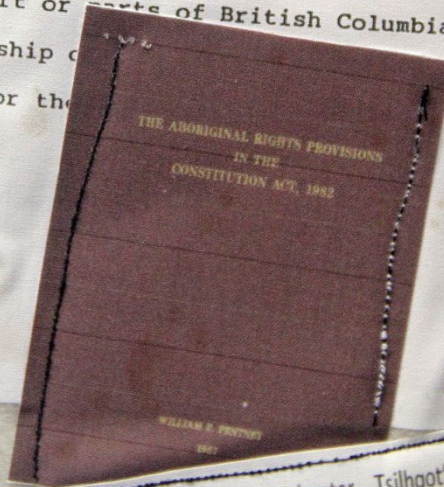






Defendant denies each and every allegation of graph 64.

Defendant does not admit that, as alleged in the Royal Proclamation is part of the of Canada; and this Defendant says that, part of the Constitution of Canada or not, the nation never did and does not now apply to the to any other part or parts of British Columbia confer any ownership of the Plaintiffs or the



With the arrival of Europeans came a dark chapter. Tsilhqot'in history intentional spread of smallpox eradicating entire families and villages. The colonial government in 1864, and successfully waged war against the colonial militia under a flag of the colonial militia under a flag of

EXTINGUISHED